

CAREER DIRECTION FOR NURSES 55+

The Thrive 55+ Career Direction Method™

Master Workbook

Name the strain. Capture your value. Investigate your options.

Sue Adair, BSN, RN

Founder, Thrive 55+ Nursing Advantage™

Table of Contents

The Starting Point	3
What this workbook gives you	3
Strain: What Is Wearing You Down?	4
Strain Scoring Guide	4
Body Load	4
Interruption and Change	5
Capture the evidence	5
Reading Your Strain Scores	6
Value: What Do You Bring With You?	6
What do I still do well?	7
Options: What Direction Is Worth Investigating Next?	7
Study the Work	8
Talk to Three People This Week	8
Compare What You Learn	10
Nursing Roles and Search Titles to Explore	10
How to Use the Role List	10
Red Flags and Tradeoffs	11
Skill Gap or Stop Sign?	11
Concern, Question, Evidence	13
Worked Example	13
Bridge Plan	15
Printable Job Reconnaissance Tracker	15
Career-to-Financial Handoff	17
Your Next Informed Step	17
My Career Direction Method	18
Reference Statement	18

The Starting Point

Career direction does not start with a job title. It starts by learning how to read the work. Before choosing a next role, you need to understand:

STRAIN	VALUE	OPTIONS
What is wearing me down?	What do I bring with me?	What direction is worth investigating next?

You are not done with nursing. You still have experience, judgment, value, and income needs. You just need a way of working that no longer leaves you dreading the next shift before the current one is over. The Thrive 55+ Career Direction Method™ walks beside you one step at a time, helping you identify what must change, recognize what you still bring, and move toward work that fits without treating you as less than.

THE PURPOSE The method does not tell you which job to choose. It helps you make a better decision before you choose.

What this workbook gives you

THE METHOD AND RESEARCH TOOLS	DECISION AND ACTION TOOLS
The complete Thrive 55+ Career Direction Method™	A red-flag and tradeoff review
A 1-10 strain scoring scale	A skill-gap-versus-stop-sign tool
Structured value prompts	A worked example
Job-posting reconnaissance questions	A printable job-research tracker
Questions to ask someone who knows the work	A Bridge Plan
A broad list of current job titles and role categories	A clear next informed step
	A bridge into the financial portion of the class

Strain: What Is Wearing You Down?

Career direction often moves forward because something about the current work is no longer sustainable. You may still care about nursing. You may still be fully capable. The question is what the work is asking from your body, attention, recovery, and ability to keep adapting.

Strain Scoring Guide

SCORE	MEANING
1-4	This is not a current problem, or you notice it but can manage it.
5-6	This is affecting your work or recovery.
7-8	This is changing how you think about your future.
9-10	This may be threatening your ability to remain in your current role.

Important: Your highest score does not tell you to panic. It tells you where to look first.

Body Load

BODY DEMANDS	RECOVERY AND TOLERANCE
Back pain	Transferring patients
Lifting	Walking quickly
Standing	Working through pain
Bending	Needing longer to recover between shifts
Reaching	

My body load score: ____ / 10
Evidence from my work or recovery

What would the next role need to reduce or change?

Interruption and Change

INTERRUPTION LOAD	CHANGE LOAD
Alarms	New technology
Call lights	Changing documentation systems
Questions	Equipment
Messages	Policies
Documentation	Staffing models
New orders	Changing expectations
Unfinished tasks	Limited onboarding
Open mental loops	Learning while expected to perform at full speed
Constant task switching	
Phone and productivity pressure	

My interruption load score: _____ / 10

My change load score: _____ / 10

Capture the evidence

EVIDENCE FROM MY INTERRUPTION LOAD	EVIDENCE FROM MY CHANGE LOAD

WHAT THE NEXT ROLE NEEDS TO REDUCE OR CHANGE	WHAT THE NEXT ROLE NEEDS TO REDUCE OR CHANGE

Reading Your Strain Scores

If body load is highest. Investigate standing and walking requirements, lifting and transfer expectations, bending and reaching, shift length, commute and parking demands, recovery time between shifts, and whether the role is truly less physical or simply physical in another way.

If interruption load is highest. Investigate call volume, simultaneous work queues, message volume, task switching, documentation pressure, productivity measures, whether work can be completed before the next task arrives, and how often you are pulled away from unfinished work.

If change load is highest. Investigate software and technology, formal onboarding, length of orientation, access to practice environments, productivity expectations during training, whether support remains available after orientation, and how quickly independent performance is expected.

My highest strain is

The problem the next role needs to solve is

The point is not to label or limit yourself. The point is to stop carrying the concern only as fear and begin using it as information.

Value: What Do You Bring With You?

This is where your nursing experience matters. You have spent years recognizing what matters, reading situations, and making decisions under difficult conditions. You have learned to read the patient, the family, the room, the shift, the unit, the workflow, the risk, and the problem before someone else officially names it.

WHAT IS GETTING HARDER?	CONDITIONS TO NAME
Lifting or physical demand	Unpredictable scheduling
Recovery between shifts	Nights, weekends, or call
Constant interruption	Productivity pressure
Pace	Commuting or location demands
Technology	Other:
Emotional wear	

What do I need to tell myself the truth about?

What do I still do well?

CLINICAL AND HUMAN JUDGMENT	COORDINATION AND SYSTEMS VALUE
Read patient and family cues	Prioritize competing demands
Explain complex information in plain language	Recognize what matters most
Organize a messy situation	Advocate clearly
Notice safety concerns early	De-escalate difficult situations
Teach without making someone feel small	Learn new systems with time and structure
Stay steady in difficult conditions	Coordinate people, information, and next steps
Recognize where workflow is breaking down	Communicate across roles and departments
Other:	

Five strengths I keep dismissing because they feel ordinary

One strength I want to carry into my next role

One work condition I do not want to carry forward unchanged

These are not simply compliments. They are evidence of your working value. They were built through judgment, context, relationships, and years of practice.

Options: What Direction Is Worth Investigating Next?

Investigating your options is not about choosing a final job today. It is about deciding what direction is worth investigating next. Career reconnaissance turns fear into information.

STEP ONE	STEP TWO	STEP THREE
Study the work.	Ask someone who knows the work.	Compare what you learn with your strain, your value, and your options.

Study the Work

Set up job alerts and allow job postings to come to your email. You do not have to apply. At first, you are studying.

WHAT TO NOTICE	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Repeated words and phrases	Phone-heavy work
Required skills	Chart-heavy work
Preferred skills	Meeting-heavy work
Software names	Technology-heavy work
Schedule expectations	Patient-facing work
Physical requirements	Travel or territory requirements
Productivity expectations	
The paragraph that explains what the person actually does	

Job title and employer

What does this person appear to do all day?

What skills, technology, schedule, or demands appear repeatedly?

What interests me, and what needs a closer look?

Talk to Three People This Week

They do not have to be perfect contacts. They only need to know something useful about a role, department, employer, or type of work you are considering.

PEOPLE YOU MAY ALREADY KNOW	OTHER USEFUL CONTACTS
Someone from another department	A quality or utilization nurse
A former coworker	Someone you meet during your ordinary workday
A nurse who changed roles	A professional contact
A recruiter	Someone suggested by the first person you speak with
An educator	

ASK ABOUT THE WORK	ASK ABOUT SUCCESS AND NEXT CONTACTS
What does this job actually look like day to day?	What makes someone successful in this role?
What is the pace?	What would you tell an experienced nurse considering this direction?
What part is harder than people realize?	Who else would be useful for me to talk to?
What technology do you use most?	
What skills mattered when you started?	
What is measured?	

	PERSON OR ROLE	WHAT I LEARNED	WHO ELSE WAS SUGGESTED
Conversation 1			
Conversation 2			
Conversation 3			

Compare What You Learn

STRAIN	VALUE
Does this role reduce the strain I am trying to solve?	Does this role use strengths I want to keep using?
NEW LOAD	INCOME
Does this role introduce a different kind of strain?	Can this role support the income I still need?
TIME	FIT
How quickly could I realistically qualify, apply, and earn income?	Does this work fit my body, attention, recovery, experience, finances, and purpose better than my current role?

Nursing Roles and Search Titles to Explore

CARE MANAGEMENT AND COORDINATION	UTILIZATION AND CLINICAL REVIEW
Registered Nurse Case Manager	Utilization Review Nurse
Care Manager RN	Utilization Management Nurse Consultant
Complex Care Manager RN	Concurrent Review RN
Transition of Care Nurse	Clinical Review Nurse
Population Health Nurse	Prior Authorization Nurse

APPEALS, CLAIMS, AND DOCUMENTATION	NAVIGATION AND SPECIALTY COORDINATION
Clinical Appeals RN	Nurse Navigator
Denials Management Nurse	Oncology Nurse Navigator
Clinical Documentation Specialist	Care Navigator RN
Medical Record Review Nurse	Transplant Coordinator
HEDIS Nurse Reviewer	Specialty Clinic Coordinator

How to Use the Role List

Do not choose a title because it sounds easier. Use the title as a search term. Search several versions. Read at least five postings. Employers may use different titles for similar work. A

title that sounds unfamiliar may describe work you already understand. A familiar title may hide demands you are trying to leave.

Red Flags and Tradeoffs

RED FLAG OR TRADEOFF	WHAT I STILL NEED TO LEARN
Physically easier but cognitively heavier	
Less lifting but substantially more screen time	
Flexible schedule with tight productivity expectations	
Remote work with heavy phone or message volume	
Meaningful role with lower income	
Strong income but extensive travel	
Familiar work with an unpredictable schedule	
New technology with limited onboarding	
Preserves nursing identity but does not solve my highest strain	
Removes bedside work but also removes the part of nursing I value	
Requires certification or education I have not evaluated	
Income takes too long to replace	

The tradeoff I may be willing to accept

The tradeoff I am not willing to accept

The question I need answered before moving forward

Skill Gap or Stop Sign?

Do not confuse “I have not done this lately” with “I cannot learn this.”

What feels like a limitation may be a need for practice, a refresher, repetition, structure, training, support, or time.

WHAT CAN CHANGE	WHAT IMPROVES WITH PRACTICE
Skills can be rebuilt.	Interview language improves with practice.
Technology can be learned in pieces.	Clinical skills can be refreshed.
New terminology becomes familiar.	Needing time, repetition, or support is different from being incapable.

A skill I have not used recently

Is it required, preferred, or merely mentioned?

What would help me refresh or rebuild it?

A technology skill I need to evaluate

What training or support is available?

My first learning step

Concern, Question, Evidence

Reconnaissance turns fear into information. Use this tool to convert a concern into a question you can investigate.

CONCERN I AM CARRYING	QUESTION THAT WOULD GIVE ME USEFUL INFORMATION	WHERE I WILL GET THE ANSWER
I will have to take too much of an income loss.	What is the actual salary range and total benefit package?	Posting, recruiter, employee
I cannot learn the technology.	What software is used, and what training is provided?	Posting, manager, current employee
Employers will not value my experience.	What type of experience does the role repeatedly ask for?	Five job postings
The role will be easier.	What are the physical, cognitive, productivity, and schedule demands?	Current employee or manager
I will need another degree.	Is additional education required, preferred, or unnecessary?	Posting and recruiter
My concern:		

The question that would give me better information

Where I will get the answer

Worked Example

THE SITUATION	THE NURSE STILL VALUES
An experienced nurse scores: Body load 8, Interruption load 5, Change load 4.	Patient education, calm communication, helping families understand complex plans, and organizing follow-up care.

THE NURSE NO LONGER WANTS	INITIAL OPTIONS
Frequent lifting, unpredictable scheduling, and prolonged post-shift recovery.	Care coordination RN, patient education nurse, pre-admission testing RN, specialty clinic RN, and care navigator roles.

Strain. The next role needs to significantly reduce physical load.

Value. The nurse wants to carry forward education, coordination, communication, and clinical judgment.

Reconnaissance finding. A care-navigation role reduces lifting but includes high phone volume, several work queues, productivity tracking, and extensive documentation.

Updated decision. The role may still be appropriate, but interruption load needs closer evaluation. The nurse now investigates patient education and pre-admission roles and asks specifically about standing, walking, phone volume, screen time, schedule, productivity expectations, salary, and onboarding.

The next informed step. Read five postings for patient education and pre-admission roles and speak with one nurse in each area.

Bridge Plan

A role can be worth investigating even when you do not meet every qualification today. Use this page to separate what you already have from what you may need to add.

WHAT THE ROLE REQUIRES	WHAT I ALREADY HAVE	WHAT I NEED TO ADD	SMALLEST NEXT STEP	ESTIMATED EFFORT

The role I am investigating

The bridge that appears most important

The first step I will take

Printable Job Reconnaissance Tracker

Use this shorter tracker while reviewing postings.

ROLE TITLE	EMPLOYER	SALARY	SCHEDULE	MAIN DEMANDS	RED FLAGS	CONTACT	NEXT STEP

Career-to-Financial Handoff

My current income

My current estimate or question about the minimum income I need

CORE BENEFITS	ADDITIONAL BENEFITS
Health insurance	Life insurance
Retirement contribution or pension	Tuition support
Paid time off	Flexible spending or health savings account
Disability coverage	Other:

How quickly would a new role need to produce dependable income?

Questions I need to bring into the financial discussion

Your Next Informed Step

You do not have to solve your whole career today. You have to take the next informed step.

START WITH INFORMATION	MOVE THE RECONNAISSANCE FORWARD
Score my three strain areas	Search three unfamiliar job titles from the role list
Set up one job alert	Ask, “Who else would be useful for me to talk to?”
Read five job postings without applying	Investigate one skill gap
Talk to three people this week	Compare one role with my full method
List five strengths I keep dismissing	Bring my income and benefit questions into Alyson's section
Start my job-research tracker	

My next informed step is

What I expect to learn

My Career Direction Method

STRAIN	VALUE	OPTIONS
What is wearing me down?	What do I bring with me?	What direction is worth investigating?

My highest strain:	One strength I will carry forward:	The first role or category I will investigate:
The problem the next role needs to solve:	One work condition I need:	The first information I need:
What I will not take with me unchanged:	The value I want the next role to use:	The three people I will talk with:

The strain I need to reduce is

The value I want to carry forward is

The direction I will investigate is

The next informed step I will take is

You now have a way to start.

Name the strain. Capture your value. Investigate your options.

Reference Statement

The Thrive 55+ Career Direction Method™ is original to Thrive 55+ Nursing Advantage™ and reflects Sue Adair's professional experience, coaching work, and educational design. It was shaped by ongoing learning from a wide range of sources over time, including career development resources, burnout education, and professional transition conversations.

Thrive 55+ Career Direction Workbook © 2020 Sue Adair | Thrive 55+ Nursing Advantage

